



and his brother then announced the enforcement of Shariah in the country and established their own court inside the masjid. The Government tried to convince the brothers not to take law in their hands but they refused. "We have a large following in the country and would implement Taliban-like Shariah," Ghazi said.

Trouble began when the Islamabad's municipal authority launched a campaign against illegal constructions in and around masjids in the capital. When the administration started the demolition of part of the Lal Masjid, said to have been constructed

illegally, students of the seminaries launched a vociferous campaign against them while the female students captured the only children's library in the capital. In May, the girl students accompanied by the men raided a house and "arrested" three women for allegedly running a brothel. Last month the students "raided" a massage centre in Islamabad and "arrested" nine people including seven Chinese, who were released after 13-hour custody.

The Government's unwillingness to take on the masjid occupants when all this was going on seriously dented its credibility. There was talk of the

STAND OFF: Militants in the Lal Masjid (left); Pakistan army cordons off the mosque

maulana having the support of Pakistan's intelligence agencies or connections in high places. "The Government must let the people know about the role of the intelligence agencies in this case and their incompetence, if not complicity in the affair," says Mian Aslam Choudhry, an MP from Islamabad.

Finally, when Musharraf acted, it came just a day after the Supreme Court—which was hearing the case of the suspension of its chief justice—issued a string warning to the government against bugging of judges houses and chambers. Many Pakistan TV channels telecast the Lal Masjid flush-out as the government's way of diverting people's attention from the setbacks it is facing over its action against the chief justice. The Government's assertion that it kept avoiding flushing out the Lal Masjid because it would have entailed casualties did not wash. Because when the General finally did strike, many experts felt he used unnecessary force that resulted in deaths. For Musharraf, there seems to be no respite from his continuing woes. ■



The masjid flush out was seen as a diversionary tactic by Musharraf to take attention away from the setbacks he faces from the judiciary

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